Research Notes: The Hype Around AI Replacing Developers

1. The Hype

For the past couple of years, people have been talking nonstop about AI replacing software developers. Much of that talk comes from the CEOs of big tech and AI companies, and news sites amplify it with headlines like "AI will replace every software engineer."

So why has it blown up like this?

- **Follow the money.** There's a massive amount of investment flowing into AI. One Medium article I came across puts it at around $202 billion in 2025 alone. "AI will replace developers" is a far more exciting pitch to investors than "AI makes developers a little faster." [7]
- **People don't really know what coding is.** From the outside, programming looks like typing code all day. In practice, a big chunk of the job is understanding the problem, designing the system, debugging, and working through requirements. [7]
- **We've heard this before.** Visual programming was supposed to replace developers in the 90s. Then low-code tools in the 2000s. Then outsourcing in the 2010s. None of them did. [7]

2. The Claims

Dario Amodei, CEO of Anthropic

- March 2025: said AI would be writing 90% of code within three to six months, and possibly all of it within a year. [2]
- January 2026 (Davos): said AI could handle "most, maybe all" of a software engineer's work end-to-end within 6 to 12 months. [1]

Mark Zuckerberg, CEO of Meta

- January 2025 (on the Joe Rogan podcast): said Meta would likely have AI working at the level of a mid-level engineer at some point in 2025. [3]

Satya Nadella, CEO of Microsoft

- April 2025: said AI writes 20 to 30% of the code in Microsoft's repositories. [4]
- Kevin Scott, Microsoft's CTO, went further and predicted that 95% of all code will be AI-generated by 2030. [4]

Sundar Pichai, CEO of Google

- April 2025: said AI now writes more than 30% of Google's new code, up from 25% the previous October. [5]

Marc Benioff, CEO of Salesforce

- Said Salesforce stopped hiring new software engineers in 2025 because AI had made the existing team more productive. [6]

Geoffrey Hinton, AI researcher (often called the "Godfather of AI")

- December 2025: warned that software engineering jobs could shrink significantly in 2026, and that AI may soon be able to take on projects that currently take months. [8]

3. Where These Claims Fall Apart

- **Some deadlines have already come and gone.** Zuckerberg's mid-level AI engineer was supposed to arrive in 2025, and Amodei's 90% figure was supposed to happen within months. Neither has played out. Companies are still hiring developers, and humans are still doing most of the engineering work.
- **The numbers are fuzzy.** Neither Microsoft nor Google has explained how they define or measure "AI-written" code, so those 30% figures are rough estimates at best. [4]
- **Writing code is only part of the job.** Real projects mean dealing with messy legacy codebases, unclear requirements, and regulations companies have to follow. That's exactly where AI still struggles. [1]
- **Even the CEOs hedge.** Benioff may have paused engineering hires, but he's also said AI isn't good enough to fully replace engineers, and Salesforce still employs over 15,000 of them, now working alongside AI tools. [6]
- **There's an obvious conflict of interest.** Many of the people making these predictions run companies that sell AI. Bold predictions are good for business.
- **Humans still have to check the work.** Even Google says engineers review its AI-generated code before it ships. [5]

Sources

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